The Margins of Early Modern Books

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The margins of early modern books are the closest thing we have to a transcript of reading, yet they are also the least reliable. A reader who underlines a sentence records attention; a reader who writes beside it records judgment; a reader who crosses it out records a change of mind. None of these acts is self-explanatory, and none of them survives in sufficient quantity to stand for a period.

Consider the Folger copy of Bacon's Advancement of Learning (1629). On the verso of the title page, beside the word "method," a seventeenth-century hand has drawn a small pointing finger toward the margin. The mark is not decoration. It is an instruction to return, and it presupposes a reader who expected to use the book more than once.

The manicule is the most legible of these marks, but it is not the most common. Brackets, slashes, and simple vertical rules appear far more often, and they are correspondingly harder to interpret. A bracket may mean "this belongs together," or it may mean "I disagree," or it may mean nothing at all beyond the momentary impulse to mark a page. Historians of reading have tended to resolve this ambiguity by assuming coherence where none may exist.

Annotation was also a social practice. Schoolbooks of the period supplied printed marginalia as models, and students were expected to imitate them before producing notes of their own. The practice therefore sits awkwardly between reception and composition: what one eighteenth-century cataloguer called "the furniture of the mind" was, in practice, furniture assembled from other people's sentences.

What survives is a sample selected by wealth, literacy, and permission. Women's copies, schoolboys' copies, and the copies of servants survive in far smaller numbers than those of gentlemen scholars. Any claim about a period's reading practice must therefore answer a prior

question about whose practice was allowed to leave a trace.

The archive of annotation is not a record of reading in general. It is a record of reading that had ink, leisure, and the authority to interrupt a printed page. Read in that light, marginalia are less a transcript than a permit: evidence not of what readers thought, but of who was entitled to write it down.

The habit of annotation was not evenly distributed across the book. Marks cluster at beginnings: the first pages of chapters, the opening of a preface, the first appearance of a technical term. Readers appear to have annotated as they oriented themselves, then stopped once the argument became familiar. A map of marks is therefore also a map of difficulty.

Digitization has changed the evidence without resolving the problem. Photographs of margins make comparison easier, but they also detach the note from the page it was written against. The texture of the paper, the pressure of the pen, and the distance between note and text are precisely the details that a scan tends to lose, and precisely the details on which interpretation depends.